make purchase of all crops at MSP rates mandatory, changing the structure of grievance redressal systems and cheaper access to storage facilities—most demands which the government was willing to agree on and accordingly amend the laws.

However, despite assurances to include the demands in the rules, given during the round of talks with three Union Cabinet ministers on 13 November, the protesting farmers banded under various unions and began to march towards New Delhi with disproportionately large amounts of ration and fully equipped vans and trucks with air conditioners, generators and high-amp connectors.[3] Fearing that they were going to stay put for the long haul, considering the sowing season for Rabi crops had just concluded and they now had about two months to kill before a round of insecticide spraying on the fields, the Haryana government ordered the state police to stop the protesting farmers in their tracks. India was still inching out of the first wave of COVID-19 infections and could not let super-spreader events like these take us back in our fight against the virus. Violence broke out between the Haryana State Police and the farmers who were travelling on tractors and trolleys, breaking police barricades set up along the way. Under the Epidemic Diseases Act, the police mandated to control large crowds used tear gas and water cannons to stop them.[4] Despite their efforts, the farmers continued onwards and by 30 November, over two to three lakh farmers had converged at various border points around New Delhi.[5] Union Home Minister Amit Shah requested the farmers blocking the border points to move to Delhi's Burari ground following which the Centre would hold discussions with the farmers on their demands.[6] Rejecting the appeal from Shah, the farmers continued to stay put at the borders, pressing for permission to protest at the more central location, Jantar Mantar in Delhi.[7] At the sites of congregation, no COVID-19-appropriate behaviour was followed. Over the next couple of months, all rounds of dialogues between the government and the farmers' unions remained inconclusive, with the latter unwilling to discuss anything or dismiss the protests until the laws were repealed.[8] Originally, the main point of contention between the government and farmers remained the MSP as the latter believed that the laws would lead the Centre to eventually dismantle the MSP system, leaving them at the mercy of large corporates. The government in all rounds